Weekend Laundry Alcove Makeover

Under $200

Transform a Cluttered Laundry Corner into a Smart, Organized Workspace in Just One Weekend

Same Space Smarter Living

CLEANER SPACES HAPPIER DAYS



BUDGET FRIENDLY

DIY SOLUTIONS

SMART ORGANIZATION

WEEKEND PROJECT

SMALL SPACE. BIG CHANGE.

30 DAY SPACES

Weekend Laundry Alcove

The Under-$200 Weekend Alcove Makeover Blueprint

Akarsh Priyadarshan

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Interior designed for Amazon KDP print (6 × 9 in) and Kindle.

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CHAPTER

The Under-$200 Weekend Alcove Makeover Blueprint

By the end of this chapter, you will have a written scope: the space you control, the appliance setup you will build around, and a millwork budget in US dollars. This is a US-focused book. All prices are USD. Example dimensions are inches. The millwork envelope is $200 unless you raise it on purpose.



DAY 1

Scope, Audience, And Budget

IN THIS APARTMENT

Riya rents a one-bedroom in Austin. Her laundry sits in a 60 in wide alcove. She can add shelves and a folding counter if they stay removable, but she cannot move plumbing, add a dryer vent through an exterior wall, or drill a load-bearing concrete wall without written permission.

> **Write the space, the machines, and the money before you buy a board.**

This book is millwork around machines that already exist: a folding counter, shelves, and labeled storage. It is not a license to install a washer, dryer, gas line, new drain, or new dedicated circuit. Hire a licensed plumber or electrician for

those. A renter usually may use freestanding or limited-fastener millwork if the lease and HOA or landlord rules allow it. An owner may fasten into suitable structure after checking services in the wall.

All prices in this book are US dollars (USD). The worked millwork envelope is $200 for sheet goods, lumber, fasteners, primer, paint, caulk, and consumables for one compact alcove. It does not include the washer or dryer, plumber or electrician fees, appliance delivery, stacking kits, or tools you already own. If you use the worksheet outside the United States, convert the $200 envelope and check local product names and sheet sizes.

Pick one construction level before you shop. No-drill: freestanding frames, tension poles only where the maker rates them, and nothing that depends on wall screws. Limited-fastener: a few screws into identified structure, with landlord permission, a removal plan, and a load you can actually support. Permanent: owner approval, and professional help if the wall, vent, or electrics are uncertain. Removable is not the same as renter-safe. A frame that can tip, overload hollow plaster, or block hose shutoffs is not a weekend win.

DO THIS

1. Write one sentence: balcony utility, internal wet area, or dedicated laundry closet — and whether you rent or own.
2. Write the millwork envelope in USD and list what it excludes (machines, trades, tools).
3. Circle no-drill, limited-fastener, or permanent before you sketch shelves.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Starting with a Pinterest shelf height, then discovering the lid on a top-load washer cannot open.

OUTPUT

Space and tenure written down

$200 millwork envelope defined, exclusions listed

Construction level chosen



DAY 1

Choose The Appliance Setup First

> **Shelf heights and counter spans follow the machines, not the other way around.**

Select the appliance arrangement before you choose shelf heights, countertop dimensions, or support locations. Front-load washer: door swing, loading access, service clearance, and vibration. Top-load washer: lid opening height, overhead clearance, and access to controls. Stacked washer and dryer: only an approved stacking kit for those exact models, vertical load path, and service access to both units. Side-by-side machines: width, side clearance, shared folding surface, and both door swings. Washer only: leave a future dryer path if you might add one, plus hose and drain access.

A stacked pair is not a side-by-side pair with the dryer lifted. Stacking changes the load on the floor, the reach to the dryer door, and the service path. Do not invent a homemade shelf to carry a dryer unless that arrangement is specifically designed and approved for that purpose. Do not put a washer or dryer on an improvised countertop.

A French cleat is two interlocking strips, usually wood, cut at about 45 degrees: one on the wall, one on the furniture. A cleat (without “French”) is simply a strip the shelf sits on. You will use those words later. First, write which of the five setups you have.

DO THIS

1. Circle one: front-load, top-load, stacked, side-by-side, or washer only.
2. If stacked, confirm a maker-approved stacking kit exists for both model numbers.
3. If top-load, measure lid arc before any overhead shelf height.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Drawing a 36 inch counter over a top-load washer whose lid needs more than that to open.

OUTPUT

Appliance setup selected

Stacking kit confirmed or stacking rejected

No appliance sitting on improvised millwork



DAY 2

Manufacturer Manuals Before Any Cut

> **Generic alcove numbers are planning starts. The installation manual is the rule.**

Record washer and dryer make and model. Obtain the installation manuals. Record required rear, side, top, and front clearances. Confirm ventilation and exhaust requirements where a dryer is present. Confirm water inlet, drain, and electrical connection locations. Confirm the service and removal path. Check whether a stacking kit is approved for those exact models.

A shelf, countertop, or enclosure must not reduce required ventilation, access, or manufacturer-specified clearances. If the manual and this book disagree, follow the manual. If you cannot find the manual, stop millwork that sits within 4 inch of the machine until you have it.

Electrical modifications, new outlets, and uncertain wiring belong to a qualified electrician. Never run a washer or dryer on an unsuitable extension cord. Keep water connections and electrical components arranged to the applicable electrical safety rules — this book does not publish a generic outlet-clearance number for every jurisdiction.

DO THIS

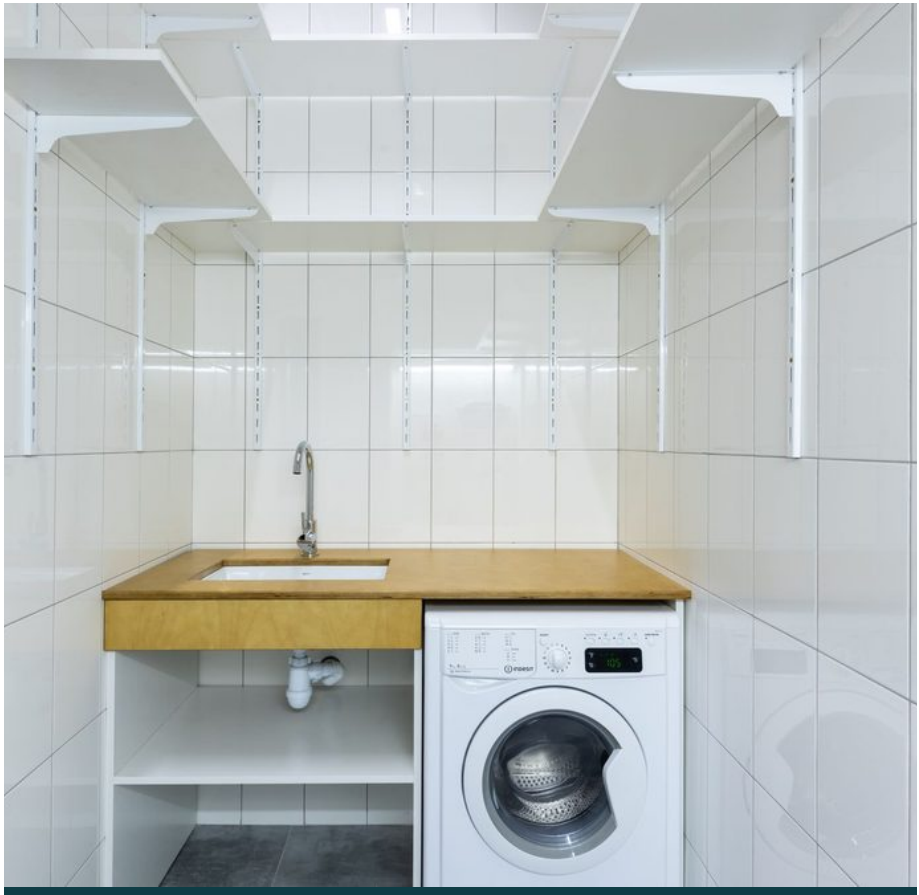
1. Photograph the model stickers and save the PDFs of both installation manuals.
2. Copy the maker's clearance table into your measurement sheet — do not invent substitutes.
3. Mark shutoff valves, drain, vent termination, and the plug so millwork cannot bury them.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Building a pretty box that covers the shutoff, the lint path, or the plug.

OUTPUT

- Make, model, and manuals on the clipboard
- Clearances copied from the maker, not from memory
- Service path still open on the sketch



CHAPTER

Space, Machines, And Materials

By the end of this chapter, you will have a verified appliance layout and a material direction that matches moisture, not a single “best” board. Cross-reference Chapter 1’s setup choice instead of re-deciding it.



DAY 1

Read The Alcove You Have

IN THIS APARTMENT

Ravi's Austin alcove is 48 in wide and 24 in deep to the plaster, but a drain box steals 3/4 in on the left. The walls are not square.

> **The smallest width, the shallowest depth, and the maker's rear clearance govern the build.**

Measure width at the floor, at mid-height, and near the top. Measure depth at left, center, and right. Measure height at the back and the front. Use the smallest width and the shallowest depth for cuts. Baseboards, tile lips, and hose boxes shrink the usable opening.

Hoses bulge. Walls bow. Doors swing. If you guess, you will cut shelves that jam at the baseboard and a counter that blocks the drain. Keep plumbing and electrical where they are unless a licensed trade is moving them.

Immediate function for most US apartment laundry closets is a folding surface you do not sit appliances on, two or three shelves, and labeled bins. That is the millwork envelope. It is not a full laundry-room renovation.

> **WHERE THIS GOES WRONG**
>
> Measuring only at chest height, then discovering the baseboard is 5/8 in thicker than the wall above.

OUTPUT

- Width, depth, and height recorded at multiple points
- Smallest width and shallowest depth circled for cuts
- No plumbing or electrical moves on the DIY list



DAY 2

Moisture Suitability By Material

> **No sheet good is universally right for a damp laundry alcove.**

Plywood (typically 3/4 in for a folding counter, 1/2 in or 3/4 in for shelves): better moisture behavior than raw MDF if edges are sealed; still needs edge protection and a washable finish. Medium-density fibreboard (MDF): smooth for paint, cheaper, swells fast if edges stay raw — poor as an unsealed counter in a wet alcove. Melamine-faced board: wipeable face, vulnerable at every cut edge unless banded. Finish: bonding primer on every cut, then satin or semi-gloss enamel; add a water-based polyurethane on a folding counter if the product allows it over paint.

Shelves hold bottles and baskets. A folding counter is a work surface for laundry, not a stand for a washer or dryer unless the whole assembly is designed and approved for that load. Concentrated loads — a person leaning, a wet basket — matter more than a uniformly distributed textbook load.

Choose by moisture exposure, ventilation, the load, and how well you will seal edges. Skip exotic boards for a weekend envelope. Skip untreated particle board in the splash zone.

> **WHERE THIS GOES WRONG**
>
> Using raw MDF as a splash-zone counter because it was cheaper per sheet.

OUTPUT

- Counter material and thickness written
- Shelf material written, with edge-seal method
- No appliance load assigned to an improvised top



DAY 3

Layout After The Machines Are Chosen

IN THIS APARTMENT

Aditi's Brooklyn wet area has a window on one side. She already chose a front-load washer with a ventless dryer stacked on a factory kit. Overhead shelves sit beside the stack, not over the dryer exhaust path — there is no exhaust duct, but the kit still needs the maker's top clearance.

Zones follow doors, lids, vents, and shutoffs.

Put detergent within a short reach of the washer door or lid. Keep tall bottles where they cannot fall onto controls. Draw the door or lid arc on the sketch. Leave the shutoff valves, drain hose, and plug reachable without unscrewing millwork.

Vented dryers need a clear exhaust path; ventless dryers do not use that duct, but they still have maker clearances and lint access. Do not assume every US home has the same dryer type. A shelf near an exhaust route is allowed only if the installation instructions still work.

Bring the sketch to the home center. Do not cut to an example width from later chapters until this sketch matches your smallest measurements and the manuals.

> **WHERE THIS GOES WRONG**
>
> A beautiful overhead box that the stacked dryer cannot be removed through.

OUTPUT

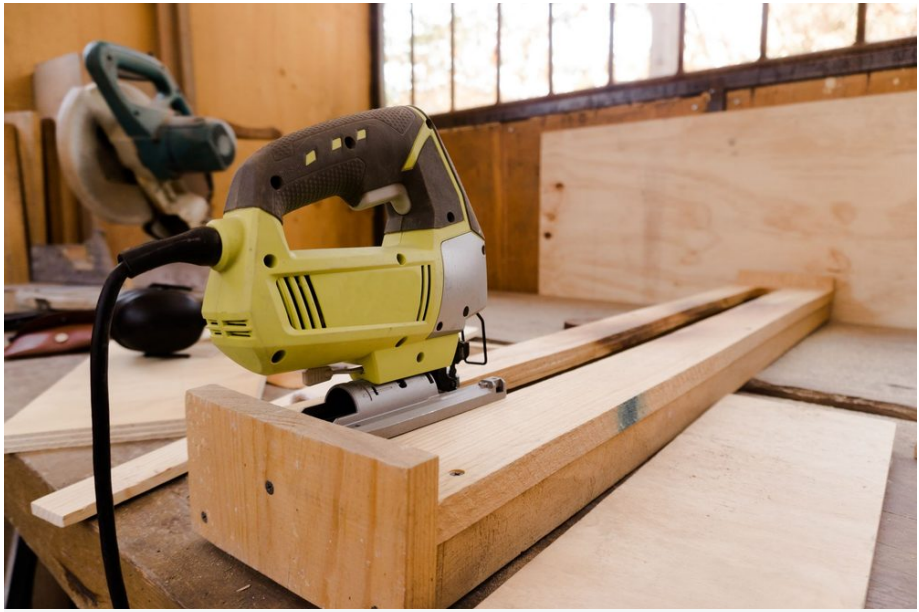
- Door or lid arc drawn
- Shutoffs, drain, plug, and lint access marked reachable
- Dryer type (vented, ventless, or none) written



CHAPTER

Building A Sturdy Laundry Countertop

By the end of this chapter, you will know what the counter is for, which material and thickness you will use, and that any span example is illustrative — not a universal design rule. Output: a counter decision, not a cut yet.



DAY 1

What The Counter Is For

> **Name the job of the top before you name the span.**

Most readers in this book need a folding and sorting surface over or beside machines, supported on wall cleats or a freestanding frame. That is not the same as a structural shelf carrying a dryer. Do not support appliances on an improvised shelf or countertop unless the arrangement is specifically designed and approved for that purpose.

Example Span Is Not A Design Code

Parameter	Value
Illustrative opening	**65 in**

65 inch is Karan's measured opening. Recalculate for your alcove, material, and wall.

Identify the material, thickness, support spacing, and attachment method. A common US-available starting stack for a folding top is 3/4 in plywood, sealed edges, with cleats on the back and both sides where the walls and construction level allow. That stack is a starting description, not an engineered rating for every width.

The cut-list matrix later in the book is illustrative. Do not cut materials using example dimensions without measuring your own alcove and confirming the appliance-specific requirements.

> **WHERE THIS GOES WRONG**
>
> Treating a 65 inch Pinterest span as a safe rule for 1/2 in MDF on two drywall anchors.

OUTPUT

Counter job named: folding surface, not appliance stand

Material, thickness, and support method written

Example cut lists flagged as not final



DAY 1

A Store-Agnostic Shopping Order

IN THIS APARTMENT

Sneha shops a Seattle home center, then a hardware aisle, then a paint aisle — using the lumber-hardware-paint loop.

One loop: sheet goods, lumber, fasteners, then finish.

Walk once. Sheet goods and any shop cutting first. Then battens for cleats. Then screws, wall anchors matched to the substrate you identified, and sandpaper. Then primer, enamel, and mildew-resistant caulk. Home-center aisle maps and SKUs vary by store and region. Ask what the merchant will rip, what minimum strip width they will cut, and how you will get a 4 × 8 ft sheet into the elevator or up the stairs.

Carry the bill of materials and the smallest alcove width. Reject warped boards by sighting down the edge. If the shop cannot cut below a stated width, plan those rips at home with a guide, or change the design.

The later shopping chapters repeat this workflow with local store categories. Skip any US store name you still see in an old figure caption — the rule is the workflow, not the brand.

> **WHERE THIS GOES WRONG**
>
> Buying decorative brackets first and discovering you still have no sheet for the top.

OUTPUT

- Shop order written: sheets, lumber, fasteners, finish
- Cutting limits asked before you pay
- Transport into the building checked



DAY 2

Moisture-Safe Finishing Stack

> **Seal every cut. Thin coats. Respect cure time — it can spill past Sunday.**

Prime every raw edge and cut face. End grain on plywood drinks primer; give it a second coat. Then a satin or semi-gloss enamel that the label allows in a humid room. Caulk wall joints with a flexible, mildew-resistant product after primer and before or after the last paint coat as the caulk label directs.

Water-based products often recoat the same day; they still need the labeled dry time before you load wet laundry on the top. If the weekend ends before cure, that is a successful minimum-viable weekend: parts cut and sealed, installation postponed. Do not promise every finish stack in 48 hours.

Caulk and a drip pan protect surfaces. They are not a substitute for sound inlet hoses, reachable shutoffs, and a correctly placed drain hose.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

One thick enamel coat Saturday night, then stacking detergent bottles on a tacky film Sunday morning.

OUTPUT

- Edge-seal method chosen
- Labelled dry and cure times copied onto the schedule
- MVP option written if cure overruns the weekend



DAY 2

Span, Stiffness, And Load — Illustrative Only

IN THIS APARTMENT

Karan's Austin alcove is 65 inch between plasters. That number is his measurement, not a national standard.

> **Do not treat one span example as a universal design rule.**

This book does not certify a maximum safe span for every plywood grade, every fastener, and every wall. State a span only as an example tied to a described stack. Example, not a rule: an 3/4 in plywood folding top, cleated on three sides

into identified structure, with a front edge band, is a common way readers stiffen a roughly 1500–65 inch opening. If your opening is wider, your substrate is hollow plaster, or you only have two fasteners, this example does not apply.

Example Span Is Not A Design Code

Parameter	Value
Illustrative opening	**65 in**

Do not copy this span onto a thinner board, a hollow-wall-only fixing, or an appliance stand.

Account for concentrated loads: a person leaning to fold, a full wet basket, someone sitting on the edge. If the top might be used as a seat or a step, stop — that is a different structure.

Add a center support or a shallow divider only when you have a wall, floor, or frame that can take that load without blocking hoses, vents, or machine removal. Recalculate after you measure. When in doubt, shorten the span or hire a carpenter who will stamp the method they use.

> **WHERE THIS GOES WRONG**
>
> Copying “over 62 inches add a center cleat” onto a 1/2 in MDF top on plastic anchors.

OUTPUT

Example span labeled illustrative

Concentrated loads considered

Centre support only if it does not block service



CHAPTER

From Measurements To A Working Sketch

By the end of this chapter, you will have a completed measurement sheet and a fastening plan matched to the wall you actually have. Output: numbers that feed the cut list, not the cut list itself.



DAY 1

Worked Measurement: 59 inch Alcove

IN THIS APARTMENT

Priya's Austin rental alcove, side-by-side compact machines, limited-fastener permission for two studs only if they exist — she will verify the substrate before drilling.

> **The governing width is the smallest of three; the governing depth is the shallowest of three.**

Worked example (illustrative, then you replace every number). Width: 59 inch at the floor, 60 inch at mid-height, 59 inch at the top because of a trim lip. Governing width: 59 inch. Depth: 32 inch at center, 30 inch at the right because of trim. Governing depth: 30 inch. Height: 216 inch clear under the soffit.

Washer: 27 inch wide, 82 in high, 27 inch deep cabinet, plus the hose bulge the manual names. Dryer beside it: same cabinet size. Door swing: 90 degrees, needs 2 in extra at the left casing.

Stud Spacing Is A Clue, Not A Map

Parameter	Value
Example framed spacing	**16 in**

16 inch centers appear in some framed walls. Verify every fastener location. Masonry walls have no studs.

Plumbing: shutoffs 16 inch left of center, 14 inch AFF (above finished floor). Drain standpipe behind the washer. Outlet on the right wall, keep a panel off it. No dryer duct — ventless dryer. Service path: both machines pull straight out 32 in. Those figures belong to this example. Yours come from your tape and your manuals.

How this turns into millwork: a folding top cannot be 59 inch if you need a scribe gap and you must not pinch the right-hand door. A rear cleat cannot cover the standpipe. Shelf depth starts from governing depth minus the maker’s rear clearance, not from a catalogue “24 inch” top. The cut-list chapter will show example parts for a similar width and will tell you to recalc.

> **WHERE THIS GOES WRONG**
>
> Using the mid-height 60 inch as the cut width, then jamming the top on the trim lip.

OUTPUT

Three widths, three depths, two heights written

Governing (smallest/shallowest) values circled

Shutoffs, drain, outlet, and pull-out path on the sketch



DAY 1

Fasteners Follow The Substrate

> **A load-bearing wall is not automatically the right place for the fastener you have in the drawer.**

Identify the wall before you drill. Concrete: masonry bits, suitable anchors, check for embedded services, respect landlord, HOA, or building drilling rules. Brick: do not explode a face brick for a heavy counter; use a method rated for that masonry and that load. Stud framing: fasten into suitable structural members you have located, not into the plaster skin. Drywall or hollow plaster only: hollow-wall anchors have low, orientation-dependent capacity — they are the wrong primary support for a loaded counter. Tile or wet finish: drilling can crack tile and admit water; stop if you cannot keep the hole sealed. Unknown substrate: stop and identify it.

Scribing means tracing the wall contour onto the panel and cutting to match. Shims are thin wedges that fill a gap so a cleat sits level. Service access means you can still reach hoses, vents, valves, and plugs after the millwork is in.

French cleats still need a substrate that can take the load. Two screws into hollow plaster are not a French-cleat system. If you cannot name the wall, you do not have a fastening plan.

> **WHERE THIS GOES WRONG**
>
> Hearing “load-bearing” and driving long screws without knowing whether the finish is 3/4 in plaster on brick or a hollow partition.

OUTPUT

- Substrate named or drilling halted
- Fastener type matched to that substrate
- Services in the wall considered



DAY 2

Dry-Fit, Then Finish

> **A dry fit is cheaper than a second sheet.**

Dry-fit the counter blank. Sand edges so they cannot cut skin or hoses. Pre-drill cleats. If walls bow, scribe, then reinstall. Screws into millwork should not replace the maker's machine feet or shipping restraints.

Do not trap inlet hoses, drain hoses, or cords behind a fixed top you cannot lift without unscrewing a kitchen's worth of hardware. A removable top or an access hatch next to the shutoffs is part of leak protection, not a luxury.

Organisation happens after the structure is stable and the machines can still come out. Bins do not fix a rocking cleat.

> **WHERE THIS GOES WRONG**
>
> Gluing a top down over the only shutoff access in the apartment.

OUTPUT

Dry fit done on the governing width

Hoses and shutoffs reachable after the top is on

No sharp unsanded edges in the splash zone



CHAPTER

Stacked And Side-By-Side Setups

By the end of this chapter, you will have one verified appliance layout. Keep front-load, top-load, stacked, side-by-side, and washer-only as separate problems. Output: a layout choice locked to manuals and tenure.



DAY 1

Stacked Pair In A Narrow Rental

IN THIS APARTMENT

Ravi's alcove is 34 inch wide with a bowed wall. He has a maker-approved stack kit for his exact washer and dryer models. Lease and HOA: no new exterior vent.

> **Stack only with an approved kit, and never on homemade millwork.**

Typical combined stack height often lands near 1880–78 inch, but you must use the kit and both manuals. Confirm overhead clearance, service access to both units, and the removal path. A gas dryer, where one exists, adds fuel and combustion requirements — that is not a DIY vent-and-shelf problem.

Example Narrow Stack Opening

Parameter	Value
Example governing width	**34 in**

34 inch is this rental’s governing width, not a stacking standard.

In a rental, prefer no-drill or limited-fastener millwork beside the stack, not a platform the machines stand on unless that platform is designed for the load. Vibration pads belong only if the appliance maker allows them on that floor. Soft foam pads are the wrong answer for most washers.

Example Wide Side-By-Side Opening

Parameter	Value
Example width	**62 in**
Example stud pitch if framed	**16 in**

62 inch is a different alcove. Do not mix the two cut lists.

Shelves beside a stack must not block lint access, controls, or the path to pull the pair. If the dryer is vented, the duct stays short, smooth, and cleanable — millwork does not pinch it.

DO THIS

1. Confirm the stacking kit part number against both model numbers.
2. Measure combined height and top clearance from the manuals.
3. Sketch shelves that come off without moving the stack, or that leave a pull-out path.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Resting a dryer on a plywood shelf because the alcove was too narrow for side-by-side.

OUTPUT

Approved kit confirmed

Gas dryer, if any, handed to a qualified person

Lint and service access open



DAY 2

Side-By-Side On A Private Plot

IN THIS APARTMENT

Anjali owns a 62 inch alcove in Seattle. Front-load washer and vented dryer, side by side. An electrician already confirmed the existing sockets.

> **Width, two door swings, and a folding top that does not carry the machines.**

Full-size cabinets are often near 27–28 in wide each, but your two stickers win. Leave the side and rear clearances the manuals name. A folding top sits above the higher of the two tops plus the maker's top clearance — not 1 inch because a blog said so.

Example Wide Side-By-Side Opening

Parameter	Value
Example width	**62 in**
Example stud pitch if framed	**16 in**

Recalculate from your smallest width and both door swings.

A center divider under a folding top can make hamper lanes only if it does not block hoses or prevent pulling a machine. Fasten into identified structure. This is the permanent level: owner approval, and a carpenter or electrician if the wall or circuit is unclear.

Do not copy the 62 inch width onto someone else’s cut list. It is Anjali’s opening.

DO THIS

1. Write both cabinet widths plus both door swings.
2. Set counter height from the manuals, not from a generic 38-inch washer.
3. Draw hamper lanes that still allow a 32 in straight pull-out if that is your service path.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

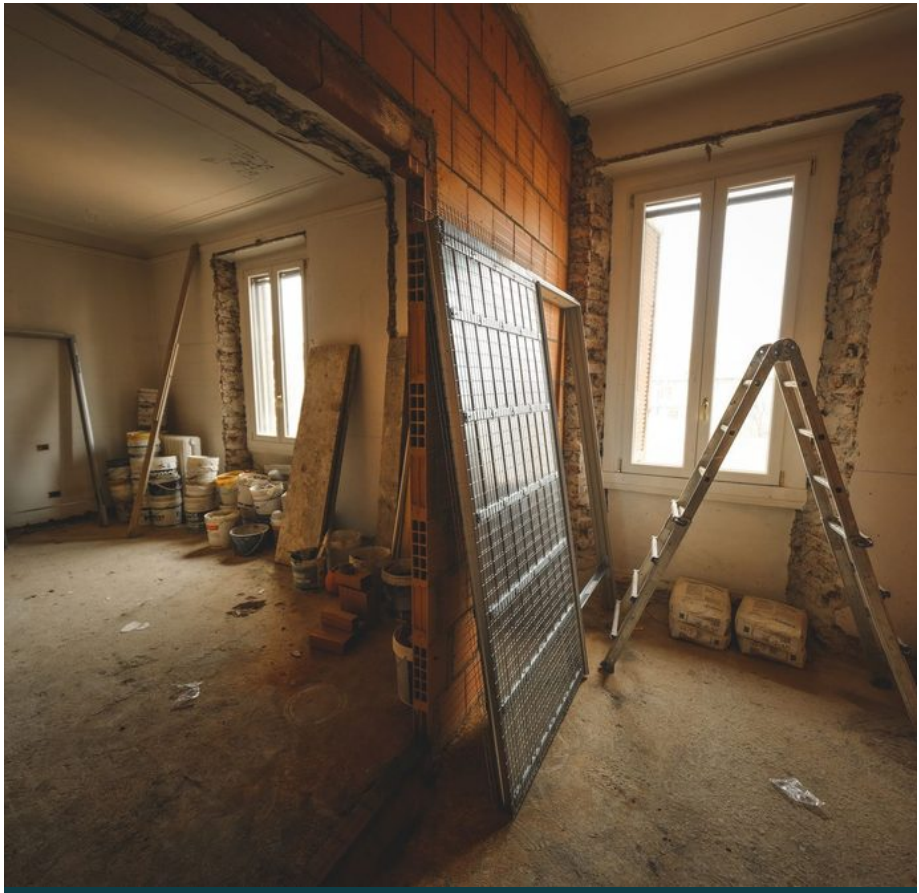
A 27 inch-deep top that crushes the vent elbow behind the dryer.

OUTPUT

Both manuals' side and rear clearances on the sketch

Counter not used as an appliance stand

Owner-level fastening matched to substrate



CHAPTER

Common Mistakes In The Laundry Alcove

By the end of this chapter, you will have a short list of stops that save the build. Each mistake is laundry-specific. Output: the stops written on the measurement sheet.



DAY 1

Ignoring Moisture And Leaks

> **Sealed edges and a drip pan do not replace plumbing that can be shut off.**

Prime every cut. Use materials from the moisture table. A drip pan is appropriate only where the appliance and floor allow it, and where you can still level the machine and reach a drain if the pan has one. Caulk is for splash. It is not a hidden-leak strategy behind a fixed panel.

Inlet hoses: inspect and replace on the interval the hose or machine maker names. Shutoff valves must stay reachable. Drain hoses must sit at the height the manual names, without kinks, unapproved extensions, or hanging unsecured.

After any move or reconnection, run a controlled short fill and watch joints before you leave the room. If you cannot see the connections because millwork hides them, the millwork is wrong.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Calling the job waterproof because the counter got two coats of enamel.

OUTPUT

Hose condition and shutoffs on the inspection list

Drip pan decided yes/no from the appliance and floor, not from habit

Leak check planned after reconnection



DAY 2

Fastening Into The Wrong Wall

> **Hollow-wall anchors are not a counter foundation.**

Heavy folding tops and loaded shelves need structure you have identified. Drywall-only or loose plaster is a stop, not a challenge to buy bigger plastic plugs.

If the wall is concrete or brick, the drill, the anchor, and the load all change. If you do not own the wall, limited-fastener work still needs permission and a patch plan.

Missing a stud in a framed wall is a reason to move the cleat or add a spreader that hits two members — not a reason to hang the same load from gypsum.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

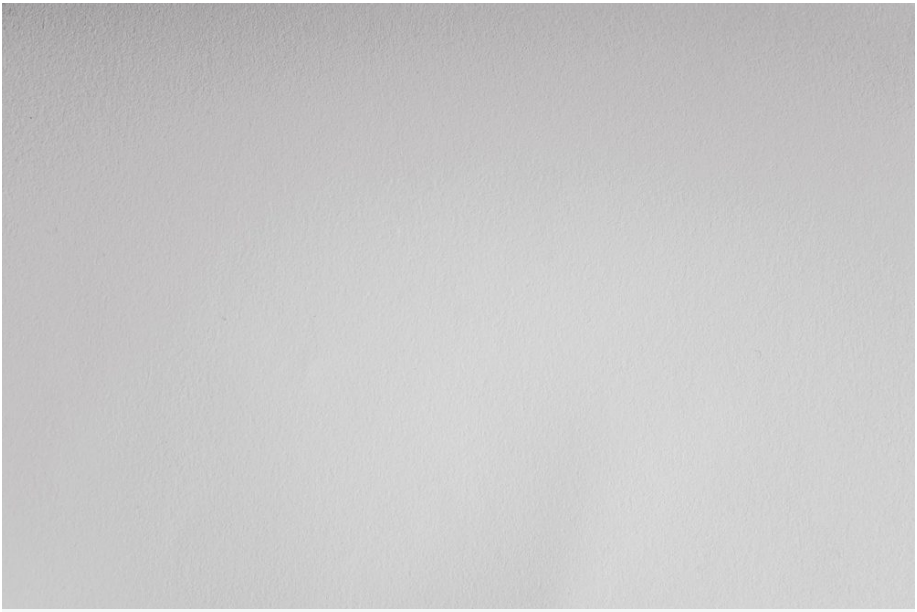
A row of hollow-wall anchors behind a 3/4 in top full of wet laundry.

OUTPUT

Substrate identified

Permission recorded if you do not own the wall

Primary load on structure, not on finish skin



DAY 3

Rushing Finish And Cure

> **The weekend can end at “sealed parts,” not at “in service.”**

Thin coats. Labelled dry times. Do not load the top until the finish can take water and abrasion as the can describes.

If Sunday night arrives and the enamel is still soft, use the machines as they sat before, with millwork staged beside the alcove. That is still a completed planning-and-prep weekend.

High-build coats stay tacky in monsoon humidity. Plan for it instead of blasting a fan into wet solvent you have not read the label for.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Declaring the alcove done while paint transfers onto dark clothes.

OUTPUT

Coat count and dry times on the schedule

MVP stop defined if cure overruns

No wet laundry on an uncured top



DAY 4

Blocking Service Access

> **If you cannot pull the machine or open the lid, the millwork failed.**

Leave reach to filters, lint paths, valves, the plug, and the drain. Removable panels beat fixed boxes in tight US laundry closets.

Review the installation guidelines for access points before you cut uprights. Future you will service this without demolishing the weekend’s work.

A stacked pair needs a path that does not require unscrewing a built-in wardrobe’s worth of sides.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

A face frame that looks like a kitchen, covering the only lint door.

OUTPUT

Lint, valves, plug, and drain reachable

Removal path drawn

Fixed vs removable panels decided



DAY 5

Moving Machines Safely

> **Do not move a washer or dryer alone with a towel and hope.**

Read the appliance's moving and transport instructions. Disconnect utilities using the proper procedure — water off, hoses drained, plug out, gas only by a qualified person. Secure drums and components as the maker requires (shipping bolts or transit bars on many washers). Use appropriate equipment and enough people for the mass of the machine. Protect flooring. Do not pinch hoses or cords. Reinstall, level, and reconnect per the manuals. Check for leaks and abnormal operation before normal use.

Cardboard is not a substitute for appliances sliders or a proper trolley when the machine is heavy or the floor is fragile. If you cannot recruit help or hire movers, postpone the pull-out and work around the machines.

Relevelling is not a coin trick. Follow the maker's feet procedure. Then do a short controlled cycle.

DO THIS

1. Read the moving section of the manual; refit shipping bolts if the maker requires them to tilt or transport.
2. Shut water, drain hoses, unplug; leave gas to a qualified person.
3. Move with enough people or equipment; never walk a full machine on its own feet across tile for sport.
4. Reinstall, level per the maker, then leak-check before a full load.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Walking a loaded washer on its feet across ceramic, then calling the new rattle "just vibration."

OUTPUT

Moving steps taken from the manual

Help or equipment arranged

Leak and noise check after reconnection



CHAPTER

Preparing For The Alcove Project

By the end of this chapter, you will have a staged tool list, a material decision, and empty alcove measurements. Output: a go/no-go for Saturday shopping.



DAY 1

Measuring The Empty Alcove

> **Empty means you can see baseboard, valves, and the true back wall.**

Clear the alcove. Record width, depth, and height at the positions in the template chapter. Note every protrusion. Do not round measurements before you have allowed for saw kerf, scribe, and the maker’s clearances.

Inch-first: write inches (and fractions) on the cut list. If a tape is metric, convert once on paper and keep inches. Do not switch units mid-sheet.

Decide shelf count only after lid/door arcs and stacked height are known.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Measuring around a machine you plan to move, then cutting to the squeezed number.

OUTPUT

Alcove empty or machines pulled with a safe procedure

Millimetres on the sheet, one unit system

Protrusions listed



DAY 1

Materials And Hardware

> **Match board and fastener to moisture and wall, then to budget.**

Re-use the moisture table. In a splashy US laundry closet, sealed plywood usually beats raw MDF for a counter. MDF can still be a painted shelf if edges are banded or heavily primed and the shelf is not a drip zone.

Cleats for load; decorative metal brackets only as a secondary look if they are rated and hit structure. Hardware for no-drill setups is different: rubber pads, furniture levelers, straps the maker allows — not a hidden screw “just one.”

Price in dollars at your home center. The $200 envelope is millwork, not appliances.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Buying MDF because a US aisle map priced it in dollars.

OUTPUT

Board choice tied to moisture table

Hardware tied to construction level

USD prices, millwork only



DAY 1

Tools, Electrics, And A Stop Line

> **A compact kit is enough; a mystery circuit is not a DIY extra.**

Minimum kit: tape, square, straightedge, stud or metal detector as appropriate, level, drill, suitable bits, clamps, sandpaper, dust mask, eye protection. A circular saw and guide if the merchant will not finish the rips.

Identify the appliance electrical requirements from the rating plate before you finalise layout. Keep the plug accessible. Do not cover junctions. Do not overload a socket or use an unsuitable extension for a washer or dryer. Uncertain wiring: electrician.

If Friday night you still cannot name the wall or find the manuals, do not shop for permanent fasteners on Saturday.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

A four-way adaptor behind the dryer “because the socket was awkward.”

OUTPUT

Tool kit packed, safety gear included

Electrical stop-line written

Manuals still on the clipboard



CHAPTER

Assess, Measure, And Plan Your Alcove

By the end of this chapter, you will have a completed measurement sheet, a locked appliance layout, and a zone sketch. This is the planning deliverable the cut list must follow. The weekend clock is real, but the $200 envelope and the appliance manuals still govern.



PLANNING

Measure, Verify, Decide, Sketch

> **Four steps, in order. Skipping Verify is how shelves get built to the wrong wall.**

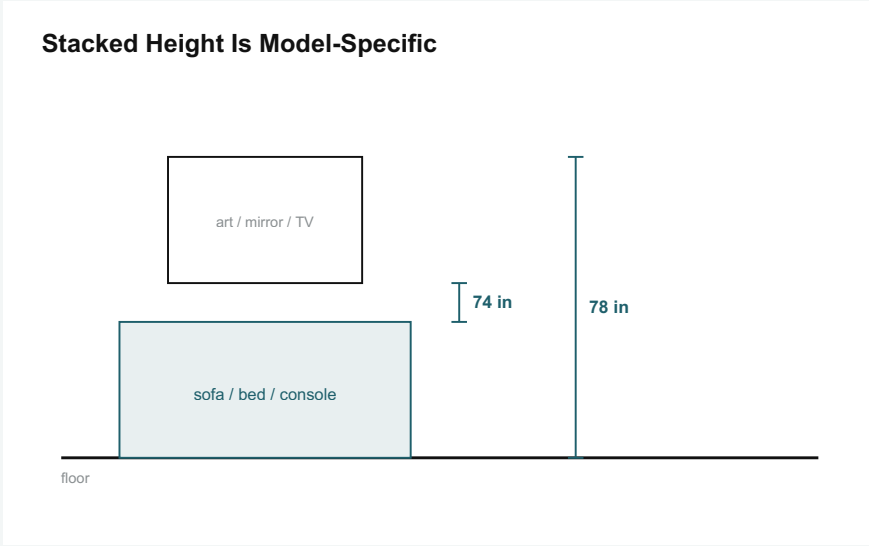
Measure. Width at floor, mid, top. Depth at left, center, right. Height at back and front. Map outlet, hose box, standpipe, gas valve if any, and dryer vent or ventless clearance. Write inches. Do not round before tolerances.

Side Gap Is A Manual Number

Parameter	Value
Placeholder only — use the manual	**1 in**

Any inch gap here is a placeholder. Copy the side clearance from your installation manual.

Verify. Square the corners. Straightedge the bow. Copy service clearances from the manuals — including vent routing and whether a drip pan is appropriate. Confirm shipping bolts are out for use, and available if you must transport. Electrical: plug reachable, no extension-cord plan.



1880–78 inch is a typical combined range, not your permission to stack without a kit.

Decide. Use the appliance table from the opening chapter. Score access, storage, and stability only after front-load vs top-load vs stacked vs side-by-side vs washer-only is chosen. Stacked needs an approved kit. Side-by-side needs both door swings. Top-load needs lid height.

Cabinet Width Is Not A Pair

Parameter	Value
Example single cabinet width	**27 in**

About 27–28 in per full-size cabinet is a planning start. Measure both machines.

Sketch. Detergent reach, tall-bottle zone, folding surface that does not carry machines, hamper path, and a pull-out path. Mark cleats that must not cross a vent. Scribe notes where the wall bows.

Rear Clearance Is A Manual Number

Parameter	Value
Planning reminder only	**4 in**

4 inch behind is a common planning reminder, not a universal vent or hose rule.

Worked numbers (replace with yours): floor width 59 inch, mid 60 inch, top 59 inch — governing 59 inch. Depth 32 inch center, 30 inch right — governing 30 inch. Two compact 27 inch cabinets will not fit side-by-side in 59 inch once you add the maker’s side clearances and a door casing; this example therefore stacks with a factory kit and puts a 250–12 inch detergent shelf to the side, not over the exhaust path.

Side And Rear Are Separate Checks

Parameter	Value
Placeholder side	**1 in**
Placeholder rear	**4 in**

Do not invent 1 inch sides and 4 inch rear if the manual lists different figures.

Dryer safety, dedicated: vented dryers need the maker’s duct, termination, and clearance; the path must not be blocked or casually flexible-hosed around a cleat; lint access stays cleanable. Ventless dryers still have clearances and lint. Gas dryers add fuel and combustion rules — qualified person. Do not assume the house has “a standard 4-inch vent.”

Copy The Maker Table, Then Build

Parameter	Value
Example side	**1 in**
Example rear	**5 in**
Example top	**1 in**

Some manuals list side, rear, and top clearances that do not match blog numbers.

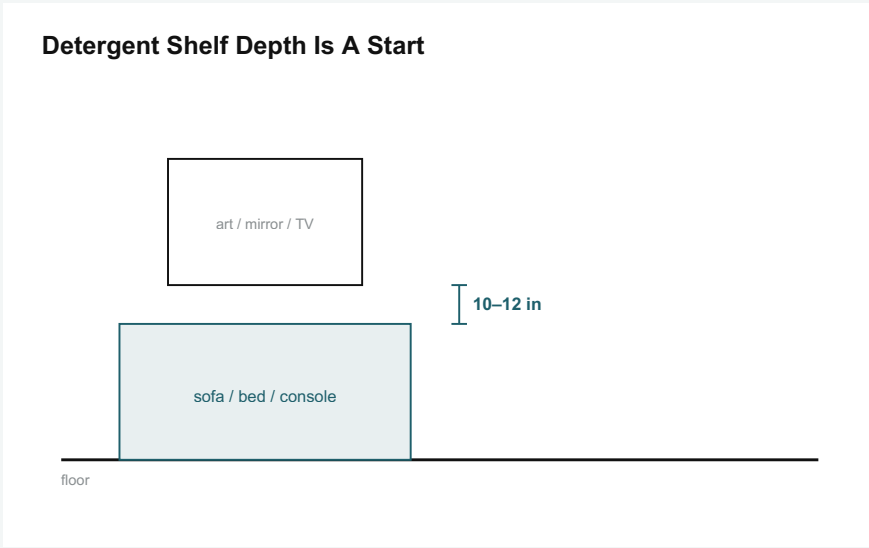
Plumbing as a system: inlet hose condition and replacement interval; shutoffs reachable; drain hose height and securing; no kinks or unapproved extensions; do not hide leaks behind a fixed top; drip pan only if it fits the appliance and floor; controlled leak check after reconnection. A pan plus caulk is not a plumbing install.

Worked Widths: Trim Lip

Parameter	Value
Floor	**59 in**
Mid-height	**60 in**
Top	**59 in**

Illustrative: 59 inch floor, 60 inch mid, 59 inch top. Governing width 59 inch.

Anti-vibration: follow the maker’s leveling. Shipping bolts removed for operation, refitted for transport if required. Excess movement can be unbalanced load, uneven floor, bad leveling, or a machine fault — stop and investigate; do not keep stacking towels under feet. Rubber pads only if the maker and floor allow them. A coin on the lid is an informal observation, not proof of a correct install.



250–12 inch is a starting shelf depth beside a stack, after you subtract clearances.

Pick the later cut-list variant only as a pattern: stacked-narrow, side-by-side, or compact side-by-side. Every dimension in those lists is illustrative.

> **WHERE THIS GOES WRONG**
>
> Measuring once at the midpoint, ignoring the vent, and cutting a 24-inch-deep top from a US example.

DECISION CHECKPOINT

- Measurement sheet complete in inches
- Layout locked to manuals
- Zone sketch includes service path



CHAPTER

Budgeting And Bill Of Materials Under $200

By the end of this chapter, you will have a staged shopping list in US dollars. Output: a bill of materials inside the millwork envelope, with a contingency line.



DAY 1

The $200 Millwork Envelope

IN THIS APARTMENT

Priya's Austin alcove millwork target is $200. The washer is already in the apartment.

Name what the envelope includes, then price locally.

Includes: plywood or other sheet goods, cleat lumber, screws and rated anchors, sandpaper, primer, paint, caulk, labels, and a small drip pan if you use one. Excludes: washer, dryer, stacking kit, plumber, electrician, appliance delivery, and tools you own. Prices move by city; treat the envelope as a shopping cap, not a quote.

If a merchant's 3/4 in plywood sheet alone blows half the envelope, reduce shelf count, skip decorative trim, or postpone the project. Do not "save" money with untreated particle board in the splash zone.

Standard US sheet goods are 4 × 8 ft. If you shop outside the United States, convert the $200 envelope and check local sheet sizes.

DO THIS

1. Copy the include/exclude list onto the BOM.
2. Get today's sheet-good prices from your merchant.
3. If the sheet plus finish already exceeds the envelope, cut scope, not safety.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Calling the millwork done at $200 while still needing a plumber for a new drain you cannot DIY.

OUTPUT

Includes and excludes written

Local sheet price recorded

USD only on the sheet



DAY 2

Material Selection Inside The Envelope

> **Spend on thickness and sealing where water sits; save on decorative hardware.**

Folding counter: 3/4 in plywood is the usual starting thickness in this book's examples. Shelves: 1/2 in or 3/4 in plywood, or well-sealed MDF away from splash. Cleats: 1x2 or 1x3 battens, or plywood strips. Confirm actual dressed sizes at the shop — Confirm dressed 1×3 size at the rack — it is not a full 1 inch by 3 inches.

Fasteners: buy what the substrate table named. Do not buy a random metal bracket set that only hits plaster.

Finish: bonding primer, washable enamel, mildew-resistant flexible caulk. Edge band is optional; paint is not optional on raw edges.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Decorative brackets and thin MDF, then no money left for primer.

OUTPUT

- Counter thickness written
- Anchor type written
- Finish system written



DAY 3

Yields From Standard Sheets

> **Nest parts on a 4 × 8 ft sheet, then recalc from your governing width.**

A 4 × 8 ft sheet is 32 sq ft. Example only: a 1480 × 27 inch folding top plus two 1480 × 12 inch shelves can come from one 3/4 in sheet if the merchant's kerf and your scribe gaps fit — check on paper, then at the saw. Do not cut that example if your governing width is not 59 inch.

Cleat linear metres: add every rear and side run, then buy a spare batten. Waste is cheaper than a second auto fare.

Kerf (the saw cut width) shortens parts. Confirm the shop kerf before you nest parts to the inch.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Nesting to 59 inch on paper and cutting 59 inch parts that cannot enter a 59 inch opening past baseboard.

OUTPUT

Parts nested on the actual sheet size

Kerf asked at the saw

Governing width used, not the pretty mid-height width



DAY 4

Bill Of Materials And Contingency

> **A BOM with a contingency is a shopping document. A vibe is not.**

List each part, size, quantity, unit USD, line total. Add 8–12 percent contingency for extra battens, a second caulk tube, or a sheet with a crushed corner.

Skip edge-band if the envelope is tight; do not skip sealing edges. Skip a fourth shelf before you skip rated anchors.

Hold the BOM next to the appliance layout. If a line item exists only to box in the dryer vent, delete that line.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

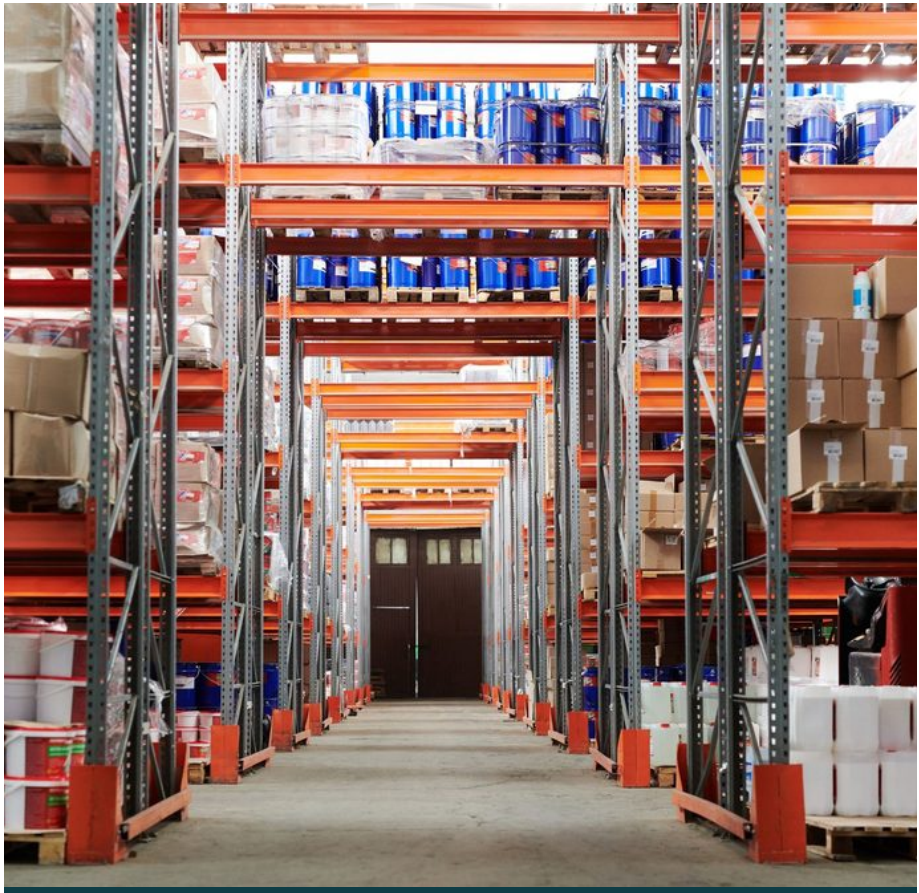
No contingency, then skipping the drip pan and the rated anchors when the sheet runs over.

OUTPUT

Line-item BOM in USD

Contingency line present

No millwork that blocks service



CHAPTER

Aisle-By-Aisle Shopping Maps And Tool Prep

By the end of this chapter, you will have a US home-center route and a packed kit. Output: a cut list marked for the store saw.



DAY 1

The Home-Center Loop

IN THIS APARTMENT

Ravi starts at a home center in Austin, not a specialty mill.

Categories beat brand-name aisle maps.

Sheet goods and store cuts first. Then 1×3 or 1×4 for cleats. Then screws and wall anchors matched to the substrate you identified. Then primer, enamel, and mildew-resistant caulk. Ask what the store will rip, the minimum strip width, and how you will get a 4 × 8 ft sheet up the stairs or into the elevator.

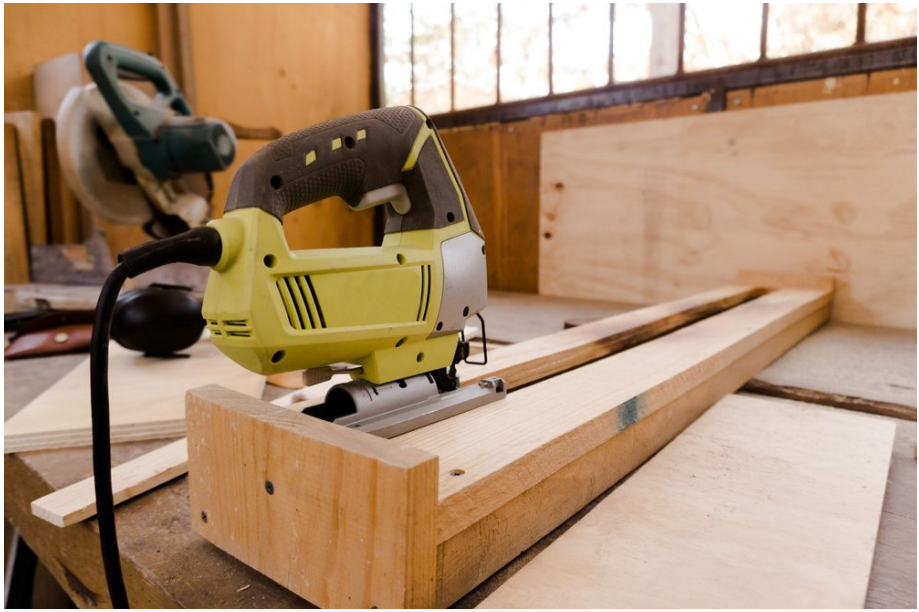
This workflow is the international version too. Follow categories even if your store’s aisle numbers differ from this map.

Carry the governing inches and the manuals' clearance notes. Reject boards with crushed corners that will sit in the splash zone.

> **WHERE THIS GOES WRONG**
>
> Walking in without a substrate plan, then buying the wrong anchor family.

OUTPUT

- Three stops listed: sheets, hardware, paint
- Lift and kerf constraints written
- Anchor family matched to substrate



DAY 1

Shop Cuts And Transport

> **The shop saw is a tool. It is not obligated to cut your 1-1/2 in strips.**

Policies vary. Many merchants will not rip very narrow strips. Mark rips with painter’s tape. Watch the kerf. Re-measure and label every piece before you leave the yard: CT, SH1, RC.

Transport: protect edges, strap sheets, know the stair turn. Two people for a 96 inch sheet in a wind. Do not balance a sheet on a two-wheeler as a personality test.

If the shop cannot cut, your weekend may end at “sheets in the room, rips on a later dry morning.” That is an allowed MVP.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

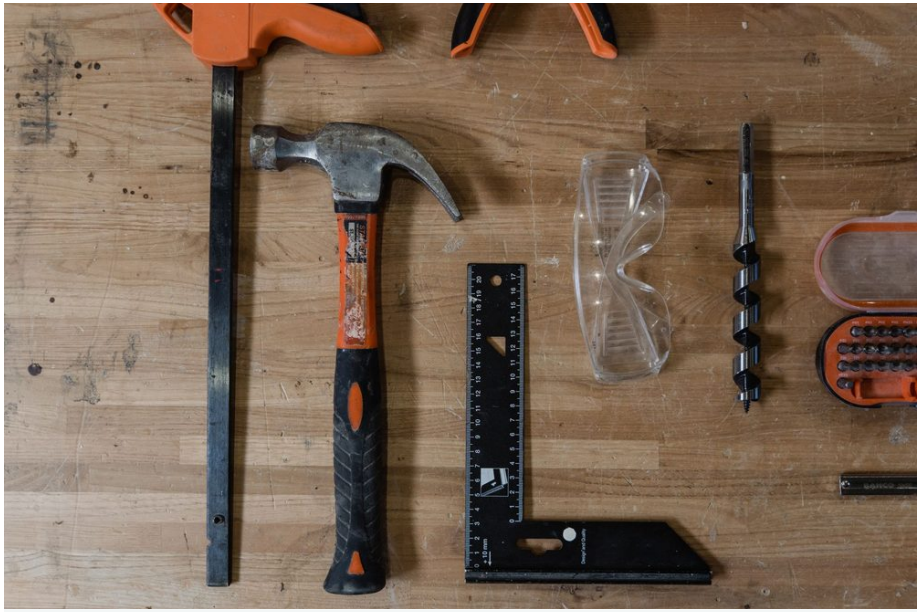
Unlabeled rips in a shared auto, then assembling the counter from a shelf blank.

OUTPUT

Pieces labeled at the saw

Transport method realistic

MVP if the shop cannot cut



DAY 1

Minimum Tool Kit

> **Borrow what you will not use again; do not skip eye protection.**

Drill/driver, circular saw with a fine plywood blade if you will rip, tape, square, level, detector appropriate to the wall, two clamps, straightedge, 120/180 sandpaper, painter’s tape, dust mask, glasses, gloves, first-aid.

MDF dust is unpleasant; cut outdoors or with extraction if you use MDF at all.

No tool in this kit is for opening a distribution board or a gas valve.

> **WHERE THIS GOES WRONG**
>
> Cutting MDF in a closed apartment with no mask because the weekend was short.

OUTPUT

Cutting and layout tools packed

PPE packed

No electrical or gas tools on the DIY list



CHAPTER

Cut Lists And Modular Components

By the end of this chapter, you will have a checked cut list labeled illustrative until your inches replace the examples. Do not cut materials using example dimensions without measuring your own alcove and confirming the appliance-specific requirements.

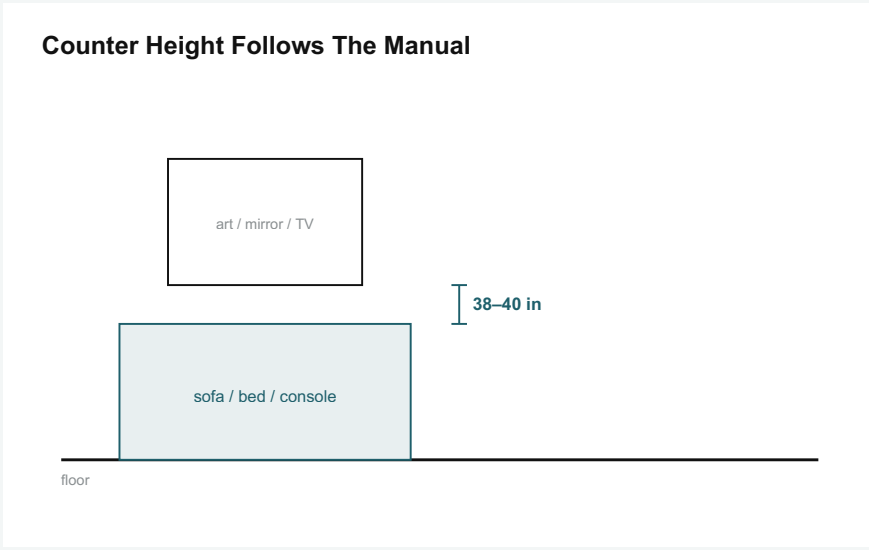


CUTTING

Illustrative Cut Lists Only

> **Every length below is a pattern. Recalculate after you measure.**

Do not cut materials using example dimensions without measuring your own alcove and confirming the appliance-specific requirements. Example lists assume inches, a folding top that does not carry machines, and clearances still matching the manuals after the parts go in. They do not automatically include your wall bow, your baseboard, or your sheet thickness.



38–40 in is a common front-load cabinet range. Add the maker's top clearance; never bury a top-load lid.

Three patterns. Side-by-side: a full folding top, rear and side cleats, optional short uprights — only if width after clearances allows both doors. Stacked-narrow: a cleat ladder beside the stack, shelves, a small side ledge — only with an approved stack kit. Compact side-by-side: a shorter top and a center support if, and only if, that support has somewhere honest to land and does not block hoses.

Pattern: Side-By-Side Openings

Parameter	Value
Example upper width band	**72 in**

Illustrative band 1470–72 inch. Recalculate; this is not a product size.

Starting sizes to adjust, not to copy: folding top depth often 24–25 in so hoses behind the machines still breathe — verify against cabinet depth plus rear clearance. Shelf depth 250–12 inch for bottles. Vertical gaps 350–16 inch for tall bottles, 250–12 inch for baskets. Cleats long enough to hit two structural points when you are on the limited-fastener or permanent level.

Pattern: Stacked-Narrow Openings

Parameter	Value
Example upper width band	**36 in**

Illustrative band 710–36 inch. Stack only with an approved kit.

Example A, illustrative, side-by-side pattern, 161 inch opening, 3/4 in plywood: top 1600 × 27 inch (scribe gap left). Shelves 1600 × 12 inch. Rear cleats 59 inch. This is not your cut list if your governing width is 59 inch or your manual forbids that depth.

Pattern: Compact Side-By-Side

Parameter	Value
Example upper width band	**58 in**

Illustrative band 1120–58 inch. Centre supports need real structure.

Example B, illustrative, stacked pattern, 32 inch opening: three shelves 780 × 12 inch and a 500 × 27 inch side ledge. Recalc if the stack kit needs different side clearance.

Machine Depth Is Not Counter Depth

Parameter	Value
Example cabinet depth	**31–34 in**

Cabinets often run 790–34 inch deep including some hose bulge. The folding top is usually shallower.

Example C, illustrative, compact side-by-side, 52 in opening: top 51 × 24 in plus a center support only on identified structure.

Tall-Bottle Shelf Gap

Parameter	Value
Starting shelf gap	**14–16 in**

350–16 inch vertical is a starting point for tall bottles. Measure the bottles you own.

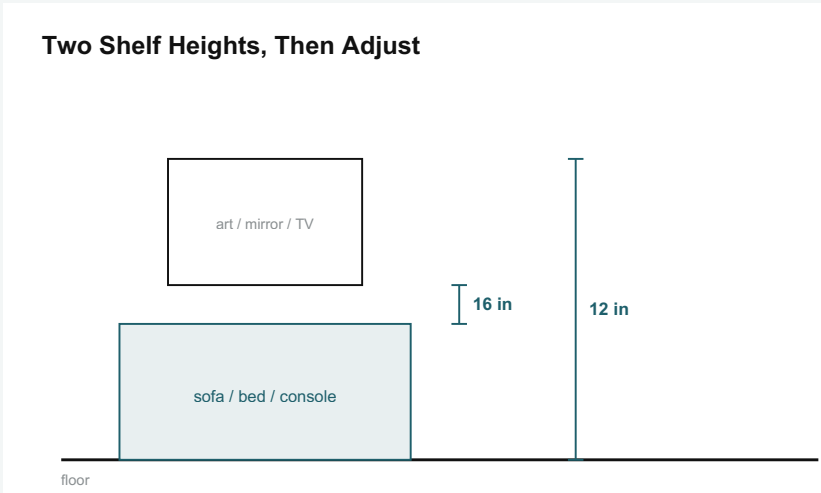
Edges: paint, iron-on band, or a timber lip. Jig: straightedge plus a spacer block. Labels on the hidden face: CT, SH1, RC. Pre-drill. Leave a scribe gap. Span at least two honest structure points for a loaded cleat. Sparse drywall screws are not a system.

Basket Shelf Gap

Parameter	Value
Starting shelf gap	**10–12 in**

250–12 inch vertical is a starting point for baskets.

Counter height: above the higher machine plus the maker’s top clearance. Many front-load cabinets are near 38–40 in high; your sticker wins. Never drop a top onto a top-load lid arc.



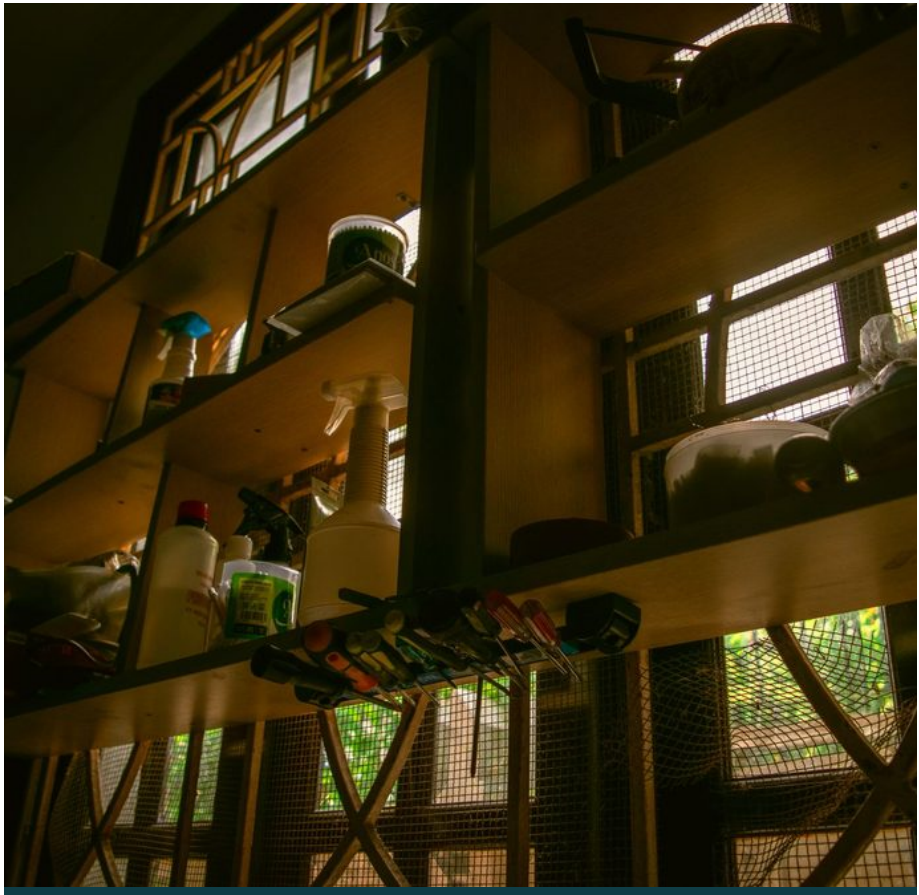
Example starting elevations only. Lock them after lid/door arcs and stacked height.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Cutting Example A on Saturday because the chapter printed 127 inch and your alcove “looks about that.”

DECISION CHECKPOINT

- Example list copied, then every number replaced with yours
- Configuration named (stack / side-by-side / compact)
- Thickness, scribe, and clearance allowances included



CHAPTER

Renter-Friendly Build And Smart Storage

By the end of this chapter, you will have chosen no-drill, limited-fastener, or you will have stopped because the job is permanent work. Removable is not automatically renter-safe. Output: a stability plan, a permission note, and a removal plan.



DAY 1 MORNING

No-Drill Base And Floor

IN THIS APARTMENT

Mia’s Austin alcove is 30 inch. Lease: no wall drilling.

> **If the wall cannot be used, the floor and a designed frame must do the work — or you scale down.**

No-drill means freestanding or fully removable parts that do not rely on wall attachment. A homemade 2×4 platform under stacked machines is not automatically safe: it changes height, drain geometry, and load. Do not build a machine plinth unless it is designed for that mass and the maker still allows the installation.

Vibration pads only if the maker allows them. A drip pan only if it fits and you can still level. Do not block hose paths.

If no-drill cannot hold your shelves without tipping, drop to bins on the machines (where the maker allows) or negotiate limited fasteners. Do not tension a post into a concrete ceiling until you know the finish can take it.

DO THIS

1. Write “no-drill” on the sheet only if zero wall screws are required.
2. Reject homemade machine plinths unless designed for the load.
3. Keep hose and drain geometry identical to the manuals.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

A press-fit frame that marks the ceiling and still rocks when the washer spins.

OUTPUT

No-drill meaning satisfied or abandoned

Machines still on the floor the maker expects

Hose paths open



DAY 1 AFTERNOON

Press-Fit Frames Have Limits

> **Friction against paint is not a verified load rating.**

A press-fit upright is a post cut slightly long and compressed between floor and ceiling with pads. Damage: crushed plaster, cracked POP, marked paint. Load: treat as light shelves only unless an engineer or carpenter rates it. Permission: still ask; ceiling damage counts. Removal: relieve pressure slowly so the finish does not pop. Stability during removal: brace before you knock the post out.

Over-tensioning can damage the ceiling. Stop when the post is firm, not when the slab sings. Do not use this to carry a dryer.

If the washer walks, the frame must not become a lever on the ceiling. Stop and investigate the machine first.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Calling a compressed 2×4 renter-friendly because it “comes out,” after it spider-cracks the POP.

OUTPUT

Light-load only unless professionally rated

Ceiling finish assessed

Removal sequence written



DAY 1 EVENING

Limited Fasteners And French Cleats

> **A French cleat is only as honest as the wall behind it.**

Limited-fastener: landlord permission, substrate identified, load matched, patch plan. A French cleat (two 45-degree interlocking strips) can hang a shallow shelf if the wall piece hits real structure. Two screws in hollow plaster are not enough for a loaded detergent shelf.

Test with a known light load first. Keep the shelf shallow. Do not hang it over a spinning washer unless the wall and cleat are rated for vibration plus mass.

Photograph hole locations for move-out. Permission in writing beats a verbal “it’s fine.”

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

A full-width heavy shelf on a 16 inch French cleat into gypsum.

OUTPUT

Written permission

Structure located

Patch kit packed



DAY 2 MORNING

Storage Zones

> **Labels are cheaper than a fourth shelf that blocks the lid.**

Sort, wash, dry, fold. Bins named for the task. Slim baskets for bottles. Nothing stored on a vent path or in the door arc.

Skip slide-out hardware that needs extra fasteners if you are no-drill.

If a bin only fits by blocking the shutoff, the bin loses.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Unlabeled tubs that migrate onto the folding top and then onto the dryer intake.

OUTPUT

Zones named

Door/lid arcs still clear

Shutoffs not used as shelf supports



DAY 2 AFTERNOON

Cables, Hoses, And Leaks

> **If you cannot see the hose, you cannot inspect the hose.**

Route cords with clips on the millwork, not stapled into unknown walls. No kinks. No unapproved hose extensions. Shutoffs remain in reach. After reconnection, controlled leak check.

Drip pan lip cannot lift the machine past what the drain hose and the maker allow.

If the frame shakes with the spin, stop. Do not add a diagonal that ties a walking machine to a weak ceiling.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Pinching the drain hose behind a “tidy” upright.

OUTPUT

Hoses visible or on an access hatch

Leak check done

No millwork used to restrain a walking machine



DAY 2 EVENING

Removal Plan

> **The last renter-friendly test is leaving without a fight.**

Rehearse the laundry workflow. Pack spackle, sandpaper, and touch-up paint if you used limited fasteners. Photograph fastener locations. Keep the cut list and permission note.

The structure must stay stable while you uninstall: unload shelves, relieve press-fit posts, then patch. Do not yank a loaded French cleat off the wall.

If removal would collapse the only support, the design was never renter-friendly.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

A “removable” unit that requires destroying the counter to reach the screws.

OUTPUT

Unload sequence written

Patch kit ready if you drilled

Machines usable without the millwork if you must strip it



CHAPTER

Owner Upgrades, Moisture, And Building Services

By the end of this chapter, you will know what permanent fastening involves, and you will have plumbing, dryer, and electrical boundaries on one page. Output: an owner checklist, or a referral to a trade.



DAY 1

Permanent Fastening Into Structure

> **Permanent means owner approval and identified structure — still not a guess into a wet wall.**

Locate structure. Confirm it is not a pipe or cable chase. Fasteners and lengths follow the substrate table. Construction adhesive is extra, not a substitute for hitting structure.

Pocket screws belong in millwork joints, not as a way to grab empty plaster.

If you cannot find structure, hire a carpenter. Vibration from a washer will announce a bad anchor at 2 a.m.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Long lag screws into an unknown masonry thickness next to a concealed pipe.

OUTPUT

Structure located and services considered

Fastener matched to substrate

Trade called if the wall is a mystery



DAY 2

Trim, Scribe, And Edges

> **Scribe to the wall; do not caulk a 5/8 in cave and call it trim.**

Scribe fillers to wavy walls. Narrow reveals look intentional; fat caulk lines look like a leak waiting to happen.

Nail small mouldings to the millwork, not only to crumbling plaster, so they move as one.

Trim must not become a lip that traps water against raw board.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Cove moulding glued over a dripping hose joint so you would not have to look at it.

OUTPUT

Scribe where the gap is structural

Water cannot sit on raw core

Trim removable enough for service if it blocks a joint



DAY 3

Finish Stack In A Wet Room

> **Primer on every cut, then a washable topcoat, then labeled cure.**

Bonding primer on raw edges. Satin or semi-gloss enamel. Mildew-resistant flexible caulk as the label directs. Optional extra clear coat on the folding top if compatible.

Humidity in monsoon months extends dry time. The schedule chapter expects that.

Finish does not waterproof a hidden leak.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Skipping primer on end grain because the enamel “looked thick.”

OUTPUT

Every cut primed

Cure on the calendar

Caulk not used as plumbing



DAY 4

Water, Lint, Vent, And Power

> **Millwork sits around services. It does not replace them.**

Plumbing system: inlet hose age and maker replacement interval; shutoffs reachable with the top in place; drain hose height, securing, no kinks, no casual extra length; leak inspection after moving; drip pan only if appropriate. Do not hide the hose box behind a fixed panel.

Dryer: vented vs ventless. Vented — follow the maker's duct, termination, and clearance; keep lint cleanable; do not crush or endlessly flex-duct around shelves. Gas dryer — qualified person for fuel and combustion. Ventless — still respect clearances and lint.

Electrical: requirements from the rating plate; keep the plug inspectable; no unsuitable extension cords; no overloaded adaptors; electrician for modifications. This book does not give a generic inch clearance to an outlet for every code. If water and electricity share the alcove, the arrangement must satisfy applicable electrical safety rules — when unsure, stop.

> **WHERE THIS GOES WRONG**
>
> A smooth painted box covering the shutoff, the lint path, and a dangling adaptor.

OUTPUT

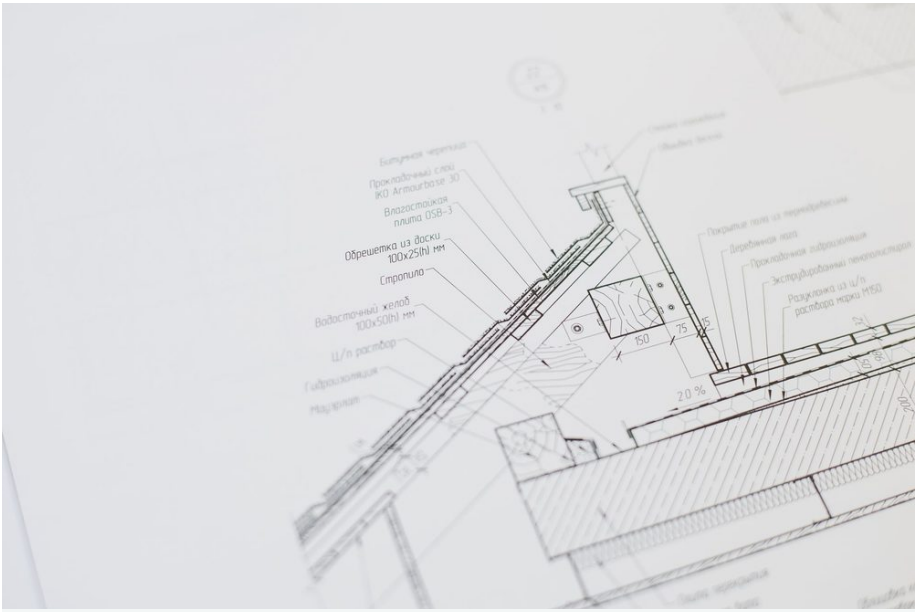
- Shutoffs and drain inspectable
- Dryer type handled correctly
- Electrical stop-line still in force



CHAPTER

The Weekend Schedule — With Dependencies

By the end of this chapter, you will have a 48-hour plan that can stop cleanly. Not every alcove finishes in 48 hours. Output: a Friday–Sunday map plus a minimum-viable stop.

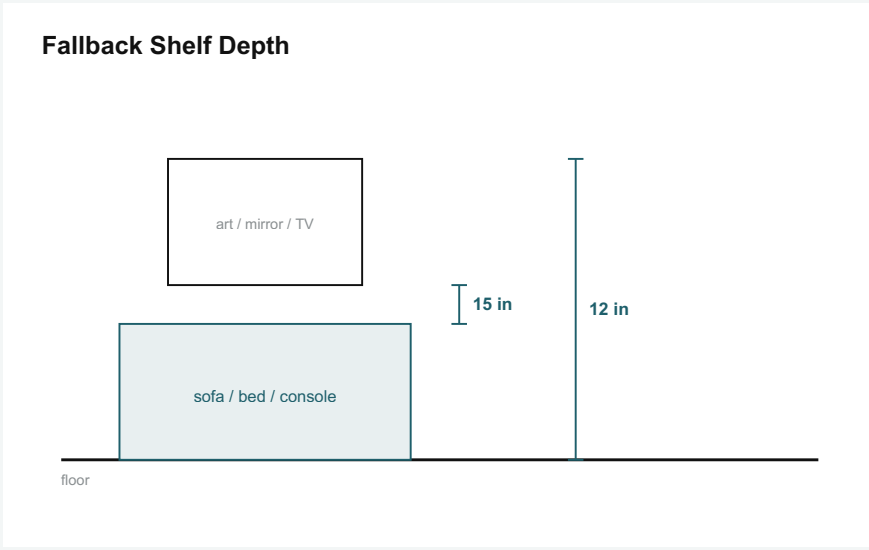


FRIDAY EVENING

Friday: Confirm, Manuals, And Stops

> **If manuals, substrate, or permission are missing, Saturday is a shopping-and-prep day only.**

Re-measure. Confirm the construction level. Confirm the appliance setup. Charge tools. Print the BOM. If the preferred 15 inch shelf depth is fantasy stock, note the 12 inch fallback on the sketch.



If 15 inch stock is unavailable, 12 inch is a common fallback — only if bottles still fit and clearances remain.

Dependencies that blow Sunday: merchant closed, shop-saw queue, lift too small, primer not dry, caulk not cured, wall not the substrate you assumed, machines not movable without help.

Minimum viable weekend: measurements locked, materials bought and labeled, parts cut and edges sealed, machines still usable. Final install waits for cure or for a trade.

DO THIS

1. Re-measure governing width and depth.
2. Tick manuals, permission, and help for any machine move.
3. Write the MVP stop in one sentence.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Promising a finished alcove by Sunday dinner regardless of monsoon dry time.

OUTPUT

- Numbers re-checked
- Dependencies listed
- MVP stop written

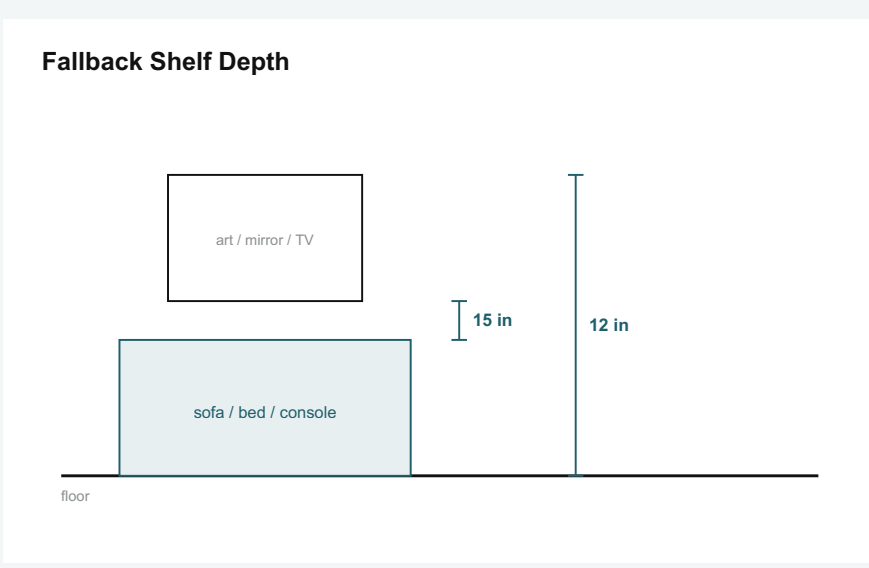


SATURDAY MORNING

Saturday Morning: Buy And Stage

> **If the sheet is wrong, do not build around it.**

Run the local-store loop. Ask kerf and lift limits. Label parts. Stage flat. Substitutions change the sketch before they change the saw.



Change the sketch before you cut. Do not mix depths on one run without re-labeling.

Transport is part of the schedule. A second trip is cheaper than a cracked sheet.

If stock fails, the MVP is “materials on order,” not “thin MDF because it was there.”

DO THIS

1. Buy to the BOM, not to aisle inspiration.
2. Label at the yard.
3. Adjust the sketch before any home cut.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

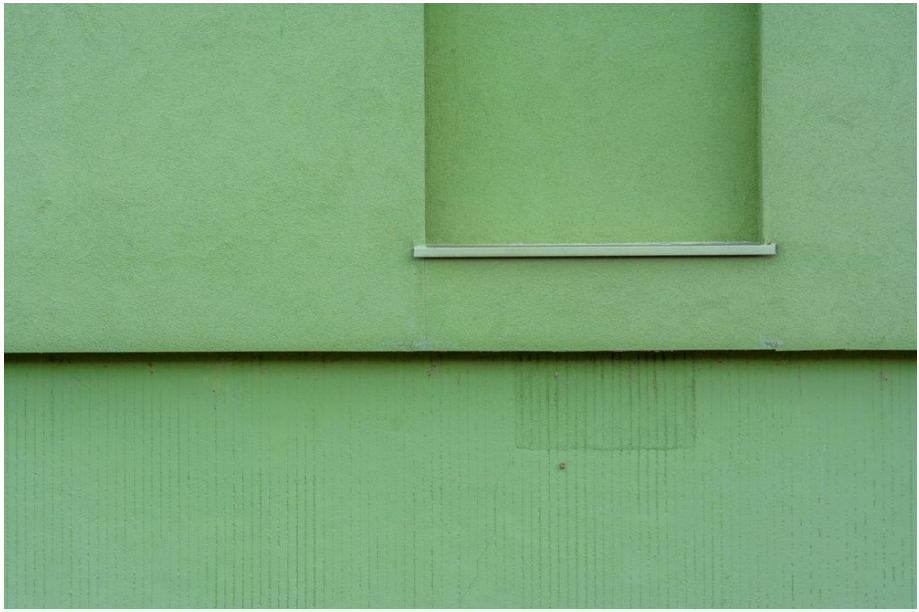
Force-fitting a warped 1/2 in board because the 3/4 in stack was out.

OUTPUT

BOM ticked

Parts labeled

Sketch updated for substitutions



SATURDAY MIDDAY

Saturday: Build Only What Is Safe Today

> **Core millwork after machines are safe to work around — or after they are moved correctly.**

If machines must move, use the moving checklist first. Then cut, install cleats into identified structure or assemble the no-drill frame, dry-fit the top, and stop if a hose would be trapped.

Decision checkpoint: if a fastener would go into an unknown wall, switch to no-drill or call a carpenter. Do not “just try a longer screw.”

Leave time. Fatigue makes extra holes.

DO THIS

1. Move machines only with the safe procedure.
2. Install structure that matches the construction level.
3. Dry-fit; do not trap services.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Rushing uprights in while the washer is still on shipping bolts you forgot to remove for operation — or removed for a move and never bagged.

OUTPUT

Moving procedure done or machines left in place

Structure matches permission

Services still reachable



SUNDAY

Sunday: Finish, Or Stop At Cure

> **Hardware after finish can take it — or next weekend.**

Caulk where the label wants a clean joint. Prime and paint in thin coats. Install hooks only on millwork or on rated fasteners.

If coats will not cure, do not load the top. Run the final inspection only on what is actually in service.

A half-finished alcove with a working, leak-checked washer is better than a glossy box over a hidden kinked hose.

DO THIS

1. Apply finish per labels.
2. Install only hardware the structure can hold.
3. If uncured, declare MVP and schedule the inspection after cure.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Loading wet towels on enamel that still films.

OUTPUT

Cure respected

MVP declared if needed

Machines safe to use either way



CHAPTER

Troubleshooting Tight Alcoves And Vibration

By the end of this chapter, you will have fixes for bow, door clashes, vibration, and moisture that do not fight the manuals. Output: a stop-and-investigate rule for a walking machine.



DAY 1

Bow, Out Of Square, And Scribe

IN THIS APARTMENT

Neha's shelf showed a wedge of light at the plaster. The wall, not the saw, was crooked.

Scribe small. Refit often.

Dry-fit, trace, cut toward the line, refit. Shims behind cleats can level a low spot; a thick shim stack is a spongy shelf. If the alcove is badly out of square, reduce depth so the part floats clear, then trim.

Cutting off too much cannot be undone with caulk in a wet zone.

A bowed wall is why the governing width is the smallest of three measurements.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

One heroic jigsaw cut that leaves a 3/8 in cave you then fill with kitchen silicone.

OUTPUT

Scribe in small passes

Shim stacks kept thin

Governing width still in charge



DAY 2

Doors, Lids, And Clearances

> **Millwork loses to a door that must open.**

If a bifold kisses a shelf, reduce shelf depth or shift it. Low-profile pulls help. Bumpers save paint.

Lid on a top-load washer is a hard stop for any overhead. Stacked dryer doors need standing room.

Do not solve a clearance fight by skipping the maker’s side gap.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Planing the machine’s door instead of the shelf.

OUTPUT

Every door and lid opened through a full arc

Maker clearances still present

Pulls and bumpers used before redesigning the room



DAY 3

Leveling And Vibration

> **The maker’s feet procedure first. A coin is not a certificate.**

Follow the appliance manufacturer’s leveling instructions. Confirm shipping bolts or transit bars are removed for operation. Excessive vibration can be an unbalanced load, an uneven floor, incorrect leveling, or a mechanical fault. Stop and investigate if the appliance walks or keeps making new noises.

A coin on the lid during spin is an informal observation. If it walks, something is wrong — it does not prove that a still coin means a correct install.

Rubber pads only if the maker and the flooring allow them. Avoid soft foam. Do not wedge millwork against a walking machine to hold it.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Treating a still coin as proof, while the drain hose beats the wall.

OUTPUT

- Maker leveling done
- Shipping bolts in the correct state
- Stop rule written for walking or new noise



DAY 4

Moisture Without Fake Plumbing

> **Catch splash. Do not hide supply faults.**

Drip pan if appropriate. Flexible caulk at the counter-to-wall joint after you can still service hoses. A splash strip behind hose connections.

Re-check inlet hoses and shutoffs. Caulk cure time is on the tube — another reason the weekend may stop at MVP.

If the floor is wet and you cannot see why, pull millwork that blocks the view. Do not add a second layer of cove base over a leak.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

A prettier splashboard over a weeping inlet.

OUTPUT

Splash vs leak distinguished

Hoses still inspectable

Caulk cure respected



CHAPTER

Measurement Templates And Labels

By the end of this chapter, you will have filled one complete measurement example and know which number governs each part. Output: a template you can photograph before you pull it down. Units are inches.



TEMPLATES

One Complete Worked Template

> **Every millwork part points at one governing measurement.**

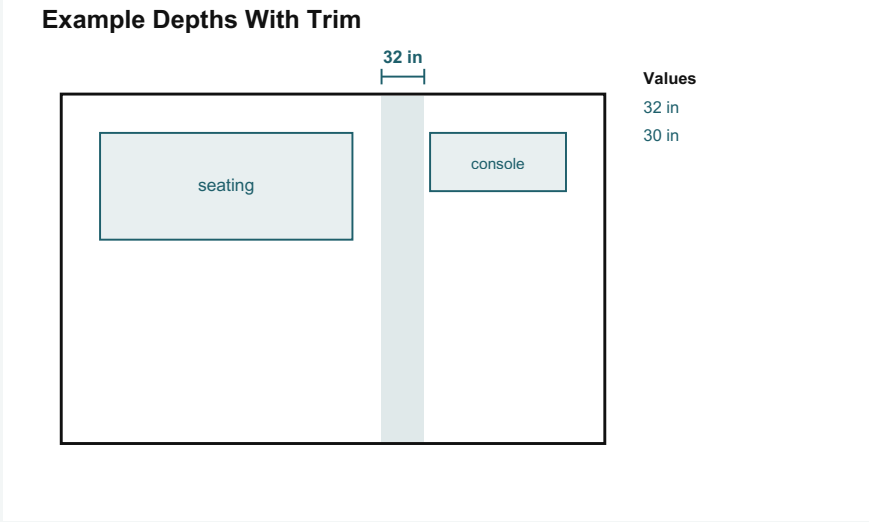
Copy this worked example, then replace it. Alcove plan: 59 inch governing width, 30 inch governing depth, 216 inch height. Widths: 1500 / 1525 / 59 inch (floor, mid, top). Depths: 32 inch left, 32 inch center, 30 inch right (trim). Appliance: stacked front-load pair on a factory kit; cabinet 27 inch wide; follow the kit's height. Door: front-load swing 90 degrees, keep 2 in to the left casing. Plumbing: shutoffs 16 inch left of center at 14 inch AFF; standpipe behind. Outlet: right wall, keep a 12 in keep-out so a panel cannot cover the plug — that keep-out is a layout habit, not a code number. Vent: none (ventless). Labels: Cleat A at 36 inch AFF for a side ledge if the kit allows; Cleat B at 56 inch AFF for detergent — both heights are examples and must clear the dryer door and lint path.

Example Cleat Heights

Parameter	Value
Example Cleat A	**36 in**
Example Cleat B	**56 in**

Illustrative: side ledge 36 inch AFF, detergent 56 inch AFF. Recheck door, lint, and kit clearances.

Which number governs what. Uprights and top length: 59 inch minus scribe minus any required side clearance. Shelf depth: 30 inch minus rear clearance minus any door clash. Side ledge depth: bottle height and elbow room, not the full cabinet depth. Cleat lengths: structure spacing, not the full plaster width if that would cover the standpipe.



Illustrative: 32 inch center, 30 inch right. Governing depth is 30 inch.

Conversion: 25 mm is about 1 inch. Use inches on the cut list. Do not mix millimetres into an inch sheet. Photograph the labeled alcove.

Incomplete sentences belong in the bin. If a template line has no number, it is not measured.

> **WHERE THIS GOES WRONG**
>
> Using the 60 inch mid width for the top because it was the largest number on the page.

OUTPUT

- Worked example copied, then overwritten with your inches
- Governing values circled and mapped to parts
- Photo of the labeled alcove stored



CHAPTER

Aisle-By-Aisle Shopping Maps For Major Home Centers

By the end of this chapter, you will have a three-stop US home-center map: lumber and sheet goods, fasteners, then paint and sealant. Home Depot, Lowe's, and Menards are examples. Aisle numbers and SKUs change — still walk those three zones in order, and still match anchors to the wall you identified.



DAY 1

Navigating Home Depot

IN THIS APARTMENT

Ravi shops a Home Depot near Austin for a compact apartment laundry closet.

> **Start at lumber and the panel saw, then hardware, then paint.**

At Home Depot, start at lumber and sheet goods — usually the back wall near the panel saw. Find 3/4 in sanded plywood for a folding top and 1/2 in plywood or MDF for shelves. Sight each sheet for bow and crushed corners. Ask kerf, minimum rip, and how many cuts they will make.

Next, the hardware bays for screws and the anchors that match your substrate — not a random toggle pack. Record the SKU from the shelf tag if you may need a second box.

Finish at adhesives and caulk: construction adhesive if your method uses it, plus mildew-resistant flexible caulk. Do not treat this store's aisle numbers as universal.

DO THIS

1. Print the BOM and walk lumber, hardware, paint in that order.
2. Confirm panel-saw kerf and minimum rip before they cut.
3. Record SKUs for fasteners and caulk.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Skipping the kerf question and taking home parts that are short by a saw blade.

OUTPUT

Thickness verified

Cutting limits known

Carry path known



DAY 2

Shopping At Lowe's

IN THIS APARTMENT

Anjali matches masonry anchors at Lowe’s for a Seattle concrete wall she has already identified.

> **The wall chooses the anchor, not the endcap.**

At Lowe’s, begin at the rear panel saw for lumber and sheet goods if you did not already buy them. Then the central hardware aisles for screws, nails, and rated anchors.

Show the clerk a photo of the wall if you can. Buy the bit that matches the anchor. Skip decorative brackets that only hit drywall.

Paint corridor last for primer, enamel, and caulk. Copy recoat times onto Friday’s schedule.

DO THIS

1. Name the substrate at the fastener counter.
2. Buy matching bits with the anchors.
3. Copy finish dry times before checkout.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Buying screws without checking length, then blowing through a 3/4 in top into a hose.

OUTPUT

Anchor family matches wall

Bits match anchors

No mystery plugs



DAY 3

Finding Items At Menards

IN THIS APARTMENT

Deepak uses the Menards yard and paint counter for a Brooklyn humidity-prone closet.

> **Yard for panels, hardware run for fasteners, paint counter for primer.**

At Menards, start in the yard or rear saw for panels and studs. Measure and record the sizes you need. Protect edges for the ride home.

Use the long hardware run for screws and anchors. Check length against your actual thickness.

Paint counter for bonding primer and washable enamel. If the label needs overnight between coats, Sunday install may wait.

DO THIS

1. Stage panels with edge protection before you leave the yard.
2. Match screw length to board thickness plus cleat.
3. Put recoat time on the weekend schedule.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Loading panels without padding and crushing the splash-zone edge.

OUTPUT

Wet-room-capable finish chosen

Cure times on the schedule

Caulk role is joints, not structure



CHAPTER

Weekend Checklist And Final Inspection

By the end of this chapter, you will have a usable weekend checklist and a final inspection you must pass before treating the alcove as finished. Output: a signed inspection, or a list of stops.



FRIDAY EVENING

Purpose And The $200 Envelope

IN THIS APARTMENT

Ravi and Priya cap millwork at $200 in their Austin one-bedroom. Machines are already paid for.

> **The checklist keeps millwork inside the envelope and inside the manuals.**

Use this list to reduce decision fatigue, not to force a 48-hour miracle. Core success is machines that still open, drain, and sit still, plus millwork that does not fight them.

Budget line: millwork ≤ $200 unless you consciously raise it. Still excludes trades and appliances.

If you fall behind, keep path lighting for the wet floor, reachable shutoffs, and a working washer. Drop the fourth shelf.

> **WHERE THIS GOES WRONG**
>
> Finishing the paint and skipping the leak check because guests were coming.

OUTPUT

- Envelope restated in USD with exclusions
- Manuals on the clipboard
- MVP stop still valid



FRIDAY EVENING

How To Use The Checkpoints

> **A checkpoint is permission to continue — or to stop.**

Print the list. Mark boxes. At each checkpoint ask: is it safe and appropriate to continue? If the wall is unknown, if the stack kit is missing, if the enamel is wet, the answer is no.

Cross-reference earlier chapters instead of rewriting them on the wall.

Keep one marker color for inches and another for notes so units do not mix.

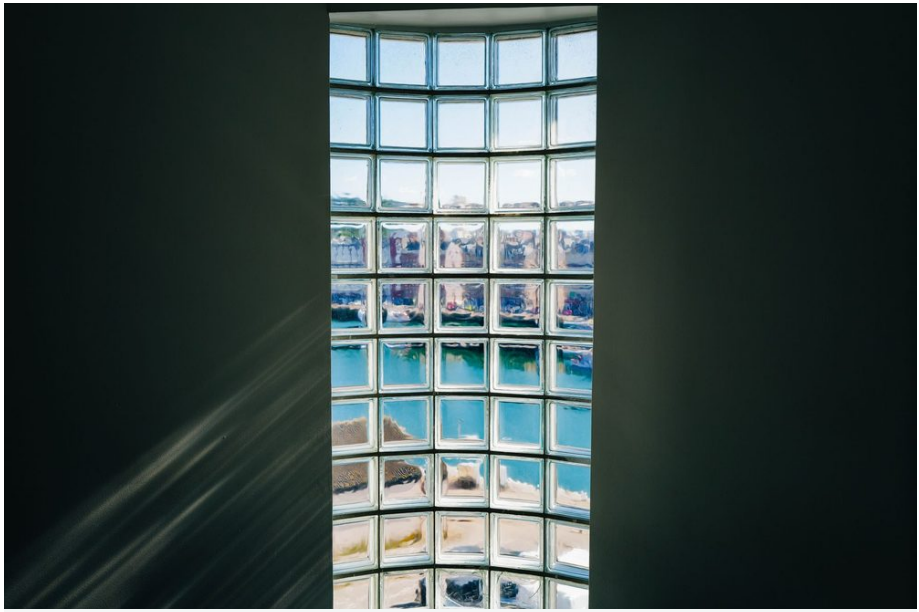
> **WHERE THIS GOES WRONG**
>
> Ticking boxes you did not perform because the section title looked familiar.

OUTPUT

List printed

Stop answers allowed

Units not mixed



FRIDAY EVENING

Friday Prep

> **Empty, measure, photograph, decide.**

Clear the alcove or pull machines with the safe procedure. Measure. Note outlets and hoses. Review the cut-list pattern you will recalc. If walls are glossy, primer time belongs on Saturday’s clock.

Confirm help for any lift. Confirm landlord permission if you are not at the no-drill level.

If you cannot finish Friday prep, do not buy irreversible sheets on Saturday morning.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Shopping first, measuring in the car park.

OUTPUT

Measurements complete

Permission and help confirmed

Cut-list pattern chosen, numbers not yet cut



SATURDAY TO DONE

Saturday Shopping And The Final Inspection

> **Do not use the finished alcove until the inspection passes.**

Shop the local loop. Verify boards against the recalc cut list. Straight stock only. If a size is missing, change the list, not the safety margins.

Final inspection, before normal use: appliance clearances and full door or lid operation; counter and shelves stable under a realistic lean and a full basket (not a person standing on them); fasteners and supports tight on the structure you named; water shutoffs and drain reachable; electrical plug accessible, no unsuitable cords; no blocked vents, lint paths, or service access; no sharp exposed edges; finishes and sealants cured as labeled; controlled leak check after reconnection; a clear removal or service path for the machines.

If any line fails, the alcove is not finished. Use the machines in their safe prior state until it passes. That is the last practical step of this book.

DO THIS

1. Buy only after the cut list uses your inches.
2. Install only at the construction level you chose.
3. Run the full final inspection; fail any blocked service or leak.

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

A photo of pretty shelves posted before the first fill cycle is watched.

FINAL INSPECTION

- Clearances and doors pass
- Leak check pass
- Service path pass



30 DAY SPACES

Your next room starts here

More room kits, declutter sprints, and measured layouts — same series language, same clear numbers.

Akarsh Priyadarshan